

Lesson 02:

Introduction & Textual Arguments

Lesson 02: Introduction & Textual Arguments

The etymological implications of the words "kitab" and "Quran" suggest that the organization of this Book is divine.

Argument #1:

- There are two main names for the Quran in the Quran: Quran and kitab كِتَاب.
- Quran comes from the word قرأ which means to recite out loud/verbally. When you recite the Quran it's an aural experience. The audible experience of the Quran would be called "Quran". The tongue and the ear are doing all the work
- When people are reading the Book, when their eyes are doing the work, the word كِتَاب is used.
- When the Quran uses the word كِتَاب it is referring to the written document and when it uses the word "Quran" it's referring to the audible experience.
- (56:77-79) "It is a noble recital, found in a hidden away book, only the most purified can touch" - ۞ ۞ ۞ لَا يَمَسُّهُ إِلَّا الْمُطَهَّرُونَ ۞ ۞ ۞
- Instead of saying that this book is found in a larger book, Allah is saying this recital is part of a larger book.
- كِتَاب back in the day wasn't like a book nowadays, it was something carved into wood or stitched together.
- Something that is carved in or stitched in order can no longer be changed.
- If you were reciting something you might change stuff, but something that's written cannot be changed.
- Allah is saying that this recital is the same as the one carved in, and the one that's carved in definitely has a set sequence.

Argument #2:

- كِتَاب is a definite name of the Quran, by calling it that name it means it has a set sequence.
- When you call something a book you're saying it has a set order. If you take any book and change its chapters around you've messed with the intention of the author. You've now corrupted the teaching process of that book.
- A book by definition is set in its sequence. Just like writing itself at the core is set in its sequence.
- Using the word كِتَاب for the Quran itself is proof that textually it is in fact a book.

- “Its gathering is our responsibility” - جَمْعُهُ عَلَيْنَا
 “Certainly its gathering is our responsibility” - إِنَّ جَمْعَهُ عَلَيْنَا
 “It is only our responsibility to gather it” - إِنَّ عَلَيْنَا جَمْعَهُ
- Allah is saying that he takes exclusive responsibility for gathering the Quran. And He said جَمْعُهُ which means the whole thing. He takes exclusive responsibility for the gathering and reciting of the whole Quran.
- If you took responsibility to compile something and then you recited it, you would make sure it would be in a set order.

There is one historical argument left that ties into the textual argument.

- In the last year of Prophet Muhammad’s (PBUH) life, he recited the entire Quran to the Angel Jibreel twice.
- Zayb ibn Thabit was in his company when he recited the entire Quran twice.
- Zayd (RA) was in charge of the compilation of the Quran at the time of Uthman ibn Affan (RA). He was in charge because he was present while the Prophet (PBUH) recited the whole Quran to Angel Jibreel.
- It is inconceivable that he would agree to any sequence other than the one he heard himself from the Prophet (PBUH).

Argument #3:

- “A book whose ayat are already stitched together” - كِتَابٌ أُحْكِمَتْ آيَاتُهُ
- When you stitch and weave each stitch is in a certain order. Ayat have been stitched together, held together tightly exactly where they’re supposed to be. If even one thread is out of place then the whole thing falls apart. This is the imagery being used.

Textual Evidence for Heavenly Order

Description: Ustadh Nouman presents another argument for the divine order of the Quran based on one of its names, adh-Dhikr (the Reminder, or that which is Memorized). He also shows how some ayat in the Quran must necessarily be looked at together with their neighboring ayah/ayat, otherwise the meaning would be incomplete or the interpretation may be misleading.

(15:9) إِنَّا نَحْنُ نَزَّلْنَا الذِّكْرَ وَإِنَّا لَهُ لَحَافِظُونَ ﴿٩﴾

- Indeed, it is We who sent down the Quran and indeed, only We will be its guardian.

One of the names of the Quran is adh-Dhikr الذِّكْر (The Reminder).

- The Quran is not Allah speaking as a speaker, but as a teacher. A teacher has goals for the students – he/she wants to get something across *to them*.
- If Allah is speaking only from the first person’s point of view (like a speaker does), we will not see:

- ﴿١﴾ قُلْ أَعُوذُ بِرَبِّ الْفَلَقِ (113:1) – Say, "I seek refuge in the Lord of daybreak", rather we would see قُلْ أَعُوذُ بِي – Say, "I seek refuge in Me";
- بِسْمِ اللَّهِ – In the name of Allah, rather we would see بِسْمِي – In My name;
- الْحَمْدُ لِلَّهِ – All Praise and Thanks belong to Allah, rather we would see الْحَمْدُ لِي – All Praise and Thanks belong to Me, etc.
- Why does the Quran speak of Allah in the third person? Part of it is because the Quran is الذِّكْر. If one were to recite it, both the listener and the reciter would be reminded and gain benefit. This is also part of the wisdom why the Quran repeats itself, because reminder necessitates repetition.

الذِّكْر also means that the Quran is something to be memorized, to be remembered (the masdar can be understood as a maf'ul).

- The essence of the Quran is not on paper, but in the chests of those given knowledge: ﴿٤٩﴾ بَلْ هُوَ آيَاتٌ بَيِّنَاتٌ فِي صُدُورِ الَّذِينَ أُوتُوا الْعِلْمَ ۚ وَمَا يَجْحَدُ بِآيَاتِنَا إِلَّا الظَّالِمُونَ (29:49) – Rather, the Quran is clear miraculous signs [preserved] within the chests of those who have been given knowledge. And none reject Our verses except the wrongdoers.
- The guardianship referenced at the beginning (ayah 15:9) includes the way we can remind each other, the way we can remember Allah, and the way it will be memorized.
- Rationally, the more huffaz (memorizers) there is, the longer time has passed, the more human error should come into play. But unlike anything else, the memorization of the Quran is divinely protected.

Western academic criticism:

- There is a worldview that the most protected kind of documents are written documents.
- Oral traditions are unreliable and prone to error – words of mouth can change slightly every time either with or without intention.
- But even written records are not fully protected! They may be altered, smudged etc. Western academics still consider this a safer road (skepticism).
- When it comes to the Quran, a different formula applies. No other document can be reproduced like this. The memorization of the Quran is so protected that even if a 'new Quran' is created and distributed to millions, it would be caught right away.
- When Islam first spread a long time ago, the possibility of an oral variation is endless, especially with limited communication between distant areas (there were no emails, phone calls, etc!)